

E-paper displays hot

Five million electronic paper displays were shipped in 2009 according to reports. One possible reason cited is the popularity of E-Book readers

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AMD's Llano samples have begun to ship. Llano consists of a Phenom II processor and an HD 5xxx series GPU. The platform is designed with utmost efficiency saving in mind

Acer Liquid

Not quite as fluid as we'd hoped

Acer's Liquid created quite a stir upon arrival. Unfortunately, it's living proof of the adage first opinions are not necessarily the last. Let that be the solitary spoiler. The handset is well packaged and the accessories while adequately encompassing have mediocre build quality.

The handset itself is quite well sculpted with a curving top and base breathing life into a basic design. The white / black colour scheme is spot on – the phone is pure white everywhere except for the top and bottom and the front that is given a translucent black finish that blends the bezel and screen into a single plane – the only interrupt here being the bold “acer” moniker above the function symbols marked on the surface and of course the earpiece that is located above the 3.5-inch, capacitive-touch display.

There's a mini-USB port on the bottom, concealed beneath a pretty good flap and a 3.5-mm jack is conveniently located on the top. Juice is provided via a 1350 mAh battery that is can do a day of sporadic surfing and three hours of call-time – good enough for most people. Interface wise, the phone is pretty snappy, although the camera lags. The 768 MHz, Snapdragon processor is nigh impossible

to slow down, though this is not always evident from the interface. Being Android-based means you're subject to its set of quirks as well – no silencing an incoming call for example – something that will annoy people migrating from the Jurassic yet call-friendly Symbian interface. There are other noticeable quirks as well. The on-screen QWERTY keypad isn't as responsive as we'd like, and nowhere near as seamless as the iPhone – you'll frequently hit the wrong keys.

The loudspeaker clarity is pretty hopeless and the device vibrates with the loudspeaker turned on and the voice is jarring. In-call volume on the

earpiece is also pretty low and at times the other person will need to speak up, or you'll miss what is being said. The headset provides higher volume and slightly better clarity than the loudspeaker/earpiece. Music playback quality is acceptable, nothing more, though better earphones should yield better results. The display is a highlight – crisp, great text visibility and good colours. Although the technical spec lists it as a 262,000-colour screen we could notice no deficiencies of any sort, videos and any sort of web browsing is a fun experience – although we wish for slightly more precision to the touch-based interaction. The camera feels like an afterthought, for not only is the quality strictly so-so, but the camera button is pretty useless – pressing it at times evokes a sudden click, when a half-press is supposed to activate the focus.

On the hardware front, we'd like a better camera with a flash, we'd also like better earphones, a better loudspeaker and a better antenna for improved in-call clarity. On the software front, while Android is replete with connectivity options, it screws up big time with the basics – a smartphone, irrespective of the bells should be a good phone and Android has problems a mile wide when it comes to meeting this end. Obviously, it would require little effort to better this, and we've no doubt this will happen, for Google

are nothing if not smart/quick learners. Android 2.1 (Éclair) is not going to address a few of our complaints though, and thanks to Microsoft's secrecy, we won't know if WM7 is a positive step up from WM6.5 that had handset manufacturers innovating with their interfaces to cover loopholes. Till then, the Liquid, like many other devices of its time faces an identity crisis – good hardware/could-be-better platform and the resulting mediocrity. Priced at Rs. 24,900, it must be said, the Liquid needs a few firmware upgrades to niggles out some of the unexpected quirks we ran into – something in stark divergence to the polished image Acer would obviously wish it projected. It's a bit pricey to merit approval anyways.

Specifications

GSM/HSDPA (3G ready);
Screen: 3.5-inch, 480x800 pixels, 262,000 colours;
CPU: Qualcomm Snapdragon 8250 768 MHz;
RAM: 256 MB; ROM: 512 MB; Camera: 5-megapixel;
Battery rating: 1350 mAh

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Price: Rs. 24,900



6/10

Features.....7
Performance.....5
Build quality.....6
Value for money.....5.5